



# **Shark Sightings and Strandings Along the UK South Coast and Adjacent Waters, January 2025–June 2026: An Observational Compilation from Citizen Science and Media Reports**

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## **Abstract**

This report compiles thirteen shark sighting and stranding records from the UK South Coast and adjacent waters (Cornwall, Devon, Dorset, the Isle of Wight, Sussex, Wales, and the Channel Islands) reported between January 2025 and June 2026. Records were drawn from wildlife trust bulletins, local news outlets, an observatory sightings log, a rescue charity stranding report, university research news, and public social media posts, and were assigned a three-tier confidence rating (High, Medium, Low) based on source reliability and corroboration. Eight species or species groups are represented, including thresher shark (*Alopias vulpinus*), basking shark (*Cetorhinus maximus*), porbeagle shark, small-spotted catshark (*Scyliorhinus canicula*), smooth-hound shark, and a smalltooth sand tiger shark (*Odontaspis ferox*) stranding on Jersey, a species only first confirmed in UK and Irish waters in 2023. The compilation illustrates both the value and the limitations of media- and citizen-sourced elasmobranch records for regional monitoring, and is offered as a descriptive baseline to support further verification and longer-term trend analysis.

## **Keywords**

elasmobranchs; shark sightings; strandings; citizen science; UK South Coast; English Channel; Channel Islands;

## 1. Introduction

Coastal waters of the English Channel, Celtic Sea, and Channel Islands support a diverse assemblage of elasmobranchs, ranging from resident small-bodied species such as the small-spotted catshark (*Scyliorhinus canicula*) to seasonal visitors and vagrants including basking shark, porbeagle, thresher shark, and, more rarely, deep-water species such as the smalltooth sand tiger shark (*Odontaspis ferox*). Systematic survey effort for these species around the UK South Coast is limited relative to the volume of incidental sightings generated by beachgoers, anglers, tour operators, and coastal wildlife groups (Ellis et al., 2005). Media reports and social media posts increasingly serve as an informal early-warning and record-keeping channel for such encounters, but vary substantially in reliability, precision of location and date, and certainty of species identification.

This note compiles and reviews a set of such records gathered over eighteen months, with the aim of (i) summarising the geographic and taxonomic spread of reported encounters, (ii) highlighting records of particular conservation or biogeographic interest, and (iii) illustrating a simple confidence-rating approach for handling heterogeneous, non-systematically collected sighting data of this kind.

## 2. Methods

Records were compiled from publicly accessible sources, including wildlife trust and rescue charity communications, regional news outlets and syndicated news articles, an island bird and wildlife observatory sightings log, university research news, a tour operator blog, and public posts on social media. For each record the following fields were captured where available: date of sighting or stranding, location, reported species, source and source type, a free-text note summarising the content of the report, and a hyperlink to the original source. Where an exact sighting date was not stated in the source material, the publication date was used as a proxy and is flagged accordingly.

Each record was assigned a qualitative confidence rating of High, Medium, or Low. High confidence was reserved for records involving a physical stranding examined or reported on by a wildlife trust, rescue charity, or governmental marine authority, typically with measurements or post-mortem findings. Medium confidence was applied to eyewitness or media reports with a named observer or organisation but without independent expert verification of species identification. Low confidence was applied to unverified public social media posts, reports lacking a precise date or location, or cases in which species identification was contested or offered only tentatively by commenters.

None of the original source reports provided GPS coordinates for the sighting or stranding location itself. The coordinates given in Table 1 are therefore approximate reference points for the named place (beach, town, or island) rather than verified positions of the animal, and are marked accordingly; they should not be used for fine-scale spatial analysis.

This compilation is not the product of a structured or randomised survey and does not support inference about relative abundance, population trends, or detection probability. It is presented as a descriptive, opportunistic record set, consistent with the general limitations of citizen-science shark and ray recording discussed by Witt et al. (2012).

### 3. Results

Thirteen distinct records were compiled, spanning 1 January 2025 to 24 June 2026 (Table 1). Locations included Cornwall (three records), Dorset (two records), the Isle of Wight (two records), Devon and Lundy Island (two records), the Channel Islands (two records, both relating to a single stranding event reported independently by two organisations), East Sussex (one record), and Anglesey, Wales (one record, included for context as an adjacent Celtic Sea/Irish Sea record). Three records (23%) were rated High confidence, six (46%) Medium confidence, and four (31%) Low confidence.

*Table 1. Summary of compiled shark sighting and stranding records, January 2025–June 2026.*

| Date         | Location                           | Species (as reported)                                      | Approx. coordinates* | Confidence | Record type           |
|--------------|------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------|------------|-----------------------|
| 2025-01-01   | Par Beach, Cornwall                | Thresher shark ( <i>Alopias vulpinus</i> )                 | ~50.35°N, 4.71°W     | High       | Stranding<br>(dead)   |
| 2025-03-25   | Holyhead, Anglesey                 | Basking shark (reported)                                   | ~53.31°N, 4.63°W     | Medium     | Video /<br>eyewitness |
| 2025-06-09   | Southbourne Beach,<br>Dorset       | Porbeagle shark (reported)                                 | ~50.72°N, 1.83°W     | Medium     | Live sighting         |
| 2026-02-08   | Boscombe Beach,<br>Dorset          | Small-spotted catshark<br>( <i>Scyliorhinus canicula</i> ) | ~50.72°N, 1.85°W     | Medium     | Stranding<br>(dead)   |
| 2026-03-14   | Landing Bay, Lundy<br>Island       | Basking shark (reported)                                   | ~51.18°N, 4.67°W     | Medium     | Observatory log       |
| 2026-03-23   | Guernsey, Channel<br>Islands       | Unidentified shark (catshark<br>group, likely)             | ~49.46°N, 2.59°W     | Low        | Stranding<br>(dead)   |
| 2026-04-28   | Porthmeor Beach, St<br>Ives        | Possible great white shark<br>(reported)                   | ~50.22°N, 5.48°W     | Low        | Video /<br>eyewitness |
| 2026-05-11   | Near Lundy Island,<br>Devon waters | Basking shark (unverified)                                 | ~51.18°N, 4.67°W     | Low        | Secondary<br>report   |
| 2026-05-21   | Cornwall coast<br>(unspecified)    | Basking shark (reported)                                   | not stated           | Low        | Social media<br>post  |
| 2026-06-03   | Isle of Wight waters               | Common thresher shark ( <i>Alopias<br/>vulpinus</i> )      | ~50.68°N, 1.32°W     | Medium     | Research<br>reference |
| 2026-06-07–8 | Greve d'Azette, Jersey             | Smalltooth sand tiger shark<br>( <i>Odontaspis ferox</i> ) | ~49.17°N, 2.09°W     | High       | Stranding<br>(dead)   |
| 2026-06-08   | Isle of Wight (Solent<br>seagrass) | Catshark sp. (cf. <i>S. canicula</i> )                     | ~50.68°N, 1.32°W     | Medium     | Live sighting<br>(TV) |
| 2026-06-24   | Brighton Beach, East<br>Sussex     | Smooth-hound shark (likely,<br>reported)                   | ~50.82°N, 0.14°W     | Medium     | Live sighting         |

\*Coordinates are approximate reference points for the named location, not verified GPS positions of the animal (see Methods).

The most notable single record is a smalltooth sand tiger shark (*Odontaspis ferox*) that stranded at Greve d'Azette, Jersey, first on 7 June 2026 and again on 8 June 2026, reported independently by a local news outlet and by British Divers Marine Life Rescue (BDMLR). The animal, approximately 4.3 m long and close to 600 kg, showed no obvious signs of fisheries interaction or entanglement; a post-mortem examination found an empty stomach and parasite load, with further analysis reported as ongoing. Both sources describe this as the first record of the species for Jersey. This fits a documented pattern of range expansion: *O. ferox* was first confirmed in UK and Irish waters only in 2023, with strandings at Lepe (Hampshire), Kilmore Quay (Ireland), and Lyme Bay (Dorset), extending the species' known range by over three degrees of latitude (Curnick et al., 2023). The Jersey animal represents a further, more easterly Channel Islands record consistent with this trend, though formal verification (e.g., genetic barcoding) would be needed to confirm it beyond the media reporting reviewed here.

A second High-confidence record concerns a 4.25 m thresher shark (*Alopias vulpinus*) found dead at Par Beach, Cornwall, on New Year's Day 2025, reported by Cornwall Wildlife Trust with early signs of trauma noted pending post-mortem results. Thresher sharks also feature in a Medium-confidence university research note describing regular summer occurrence around the Isle of Wight, consistent with the species' known preference for the south-west English coast as far east as the Isle of Wight (Ellis et al., 2005).

Basking shark (*Cetorhinus maximus*) was the most frequently reported species or species-group, appearing in four records of varying confidence: a Medium-confidence eyewitness video near Holyhead, Anglesey; a Medium-confidence observatory log entry from Landing Bay, Lundy Island, describing observation by two staff members and their guests; and two Low-confidence records, one an unverified secondary report near Lundy Island and one an undated social media post from an unspecified Cornwall location. This is broadly consistent with south-west England being one of three established UK basking shark sighting hotspots identified from two decades of public recording-scheme data (Witt et al., 2012).

The remaining records comprise a probable porbeagle shark observed feeding close to shore at Southbourne Beach, Dorset (Medium confidence); a small-spotted catshark found dead at Boscombe Beach, Dorset (Medium confidence); an unidentified shark, tentatively assigned to the catshark group by online commenters, found dead in Guernsey (Low confidence); a possible great white shark filmed among dolphins off Porthmeor Beach, St Ives, attributed to comments from the Shark Trust's chair but not independently confirmed (Low confidence); a likely smooth-hound shark seen swimming close to shore at Brighton Beach, attributed to a named Sussex Wildlife Trust marine conservation officer (Medium confidence); and an unspecified catshark, likely small-spotted catshark, observed by a snorkeller and filmed for a BBC Countryfile segment on shark and ray research in Solent seagrass habitat near the Isle of Wight (Medium confidence).

## 4. Discussion

The compiled records illustrate the breadth of elasmobranch diversity reported informally along the UK South Coast and adjacent waters over an eighteen-month period, spanning wide-ranging pelagic visitors (thresher, porbeagle, possible white shark), a seasonal filter-feeder (basking shark), resident benthic species (small-spotted catshark, smooth-hound), and a rare deep-water vagrant (smalltooth sand tiger shark). The Jersey *Odontaspis ferox* stranding is of clear biogeographic interest given its reported status as a first island record, and, read alongside the 2023 Curnick et al. records, is consistent with a possible climate-linked northerly range shift for the species in the north-east Atlantic. Formal documentation of the Jersey animal, ideally incorporating the post-mortem findings referenced by BDMLR once finalised, would strengthen this interpretation.

The recurring Isle of Wight thresher shark pattern and the multiple independent basking shark reports around Lundy Island and the wider South West suggest that these two species may be among the most consistently encountered large sharks in the region during the period reviewed, consistent with their established seasonal presence in south-west English and Channel waters (Ellis et al., 2005; Witt et al., 2012). By contrast, single Low-confidence records such as the Porthmeor Beach possible white shark sighting and the Guernsey

unidentified stranding highlight the difficulty of resolving species identity from public reports alone, even where an expert commentator is quoted second-hand.

The dataset also demonstrates the dual role of citizen science and media reporting in regional elasmobranch monitoring: bulletins from wildlife trusts, rescue charities, and observatories provide reasonably well-documented records suitable for cautious scientific use, while social media posts and secondary news summaries function more as leads that would benefit from follow-up verification, photographic review, or expert consultation before being treated as confirmed occurrence data.

## 5. Limitations

This compilation has several limitations inherent to opportunistic, media-derived data. Sampling effort is uneven across space, time, and reporting channel, and is likely biased toward locations with higher beach usage, media coverage, or active citizen science and observatory programmes. Several records rely on publication date rather than a stated sighting date, introducing possible temporal imprecision. No source provided verified GPS coordinates for the animal itself; the approximate coordinates given in Table 1 refer to the named place, not the sighting position. Species identifications for Low- and some Medium-confidence records are provisional and, in some cases, contested. Finally, two records (the Jersey stranding reported by both a local news outlet and BDMLR) most likely describe a single underlying event, and were retained separately for source-comparison purposes but should be treated as one occurrence in any quantitative summary.

## 6. Conclusion

Despite these limitations, the compiled records provide a useful, low-cost baseline of elasmobranch occurrence along the UK South Coast and adjacent waters for the period January 2025 to June 2026, and point to thresher shark and basking shark as the most consistently reported large species, alongside a notable first-record stranding of smalltooth sand tiger shark on Jersey that fits an emerging pattern of range

expansion for the species. Continued aggregation of citizen science, wildlife trust, and media-sourced records, ideally cross-referenced with photographic verification and, where possible, genetic or morphometric confirmation, would strengthen the evidentiary value of this type of dataset for regional conservation monitoring.

## Declarations

Conflicts of interest: The author declares no conflicts of interest.

Ethics statement: This report is a desk-based compilation and review of publicly available third-party sighting and stranding reports. No animals were collected, handled, or disturbed by the author in the course of this work, and no ethics approval was required.

Author contributions: O. Taylor conceived the compilation, collected and rated the records, and wrote the manuscript.

Data availability: The underlying record set, including source links and free-text notes for each entry, is available from the author on request.

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## Data Sources (Grey Literature and Media Reports)

The individual sighting and stranding records summarised in Table 1 were not drawn from peer-reviewed literature but from the following primary reports, listed by organisation/outlet. All were accessed by the author between May and July 2026; exact access dates are available in the underlying dataset (see Data Availability).

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Channel 103 (2026) Shark dies after washing up on Greve d'Azette beach, Jersey. Available at: [channel103.com](http://channel103.com) [Accessed June 2026].

Cornwall Wildlife Trust (2025) Endangered shark found at Par Beach. Available at: [cornwallwildlifetrust.org.uk](http://cornwallwildlifetrust.org.uk) [Accessed May 2026].

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